

China Solar PV Industry Quarterly Data Briefing

— Q2 2026

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Next Issue: Q3 2026 (expected November 2026)

What's Inside

本期关键词

H1 new solar installations fall 66% to 72.07 GW — but remain above 2021–2024 average

Cumulative installed capacity reaches 1.27 billion kW — set to surpass coal as China's largest power source in 2026

PV exports reach \$17.18 billion, up 24.3% YoY — first positive growth since H2 2023

Manufacturing output contracts across all four segments — polysilicon -9.8%, wafers -7.3%, cells -21.9%, modules -35.1%

Three mandatory national energy efficiency standards for PV take effect January 1, 2027

Global PV additions forecast at 612 GW in 2026, down 8% YoY, rebounding to 864 GW by 2030

Three numbers that matter

H1 2026 new solar installations fell 66% to 72.07 GW, down from 212.21 GW in H1 2025. But as CPIA emphasized, this is a “return to rationalization” — H1 2026 installations remain above the 2021–2024 H1 average, with monthly variability at its lowest in five years.

****PV exports reached \$17.18 billion in H1 2026****, up 24.3% year-over-year. Component exports grew 14% in value despite a 2.5% volume decline — the first value growth since the H2 2023 downturn. June component exports alone reached \$2.15 billion.

Cumulative PV installed capacity reached 1.27 billion kW by end-June, up 15.8% YoY. The National Energy Administration confirmed PV capacity will surpass coal-fired power in 2026 to become **China’s largest power source**.

What changed this quarter

Export tax rebate on all PV products eliminated effective April 1, triggering a March export surge followed by Q2 slowdown

Three mandatory national energy efficiency standards for silicon wafers, PV modules, and inverters announced — take effect January 1, 2027

MIIT released mandatory national standards for PV and smart connected vehicles as part of “involution-style” competition regulation

CPIA revised 2026 domestic installation forecast down to 180–240 GW from 315 GW in 2025

BloombergNEF forecasts 2026 global PV additions at 612 GW, down 8% YoY

Part 1: Installed Capacity & Market Overview

1.1 Cumulative Installed Capacity

As of June 30, 2026, China’s cumulative solar PV installed capacity reached **1.27 billion kW (1,270 GW)**, up **15.8% year-over-year**.

The National Energy Administration confirmed that PV capacity will surpass coal-fired power capacity in 2026 to become **China’s largest power source**. PV generation grew over 40% YoY in H1, with midday peak output accounting for one-third of generation during summer peak periods.

1.2 New Installations

H1 2026 new solar installations: 72.07 GW, down **66% year-over-year** from 212.21 GW in H1 2025.

Monthly breakdown (H1 2026):

Period	New Installations (GW)	Notes
Jan–Feb	—	Within five-year median range
March	—	—
April	—	—
May	—	—
June	12.48	Down 13.09% YoY from 14.36 GW in

Period	New Installations (GW)	Notes
		June 2025
H1 Total	72.07	Down 66% YoY

Key context from CPIA:

H1 2026 installations remain **above the 2021–2024 H1 average**

Monthly installation variability is at its **lowest in five years** — the industry is shifting from “pulse-style growth” to “steady growth”

The decline is a correction from the **abnormally high 2025 H1 base** (212 GW, +107% YoY), not a trend reversal

1.3 2026 Full-Year Forecast

The China Photovoltaic Industry Association (CPIA) revised its 2026 domestic installation forecast down to **180–240 GW** in February 2026, a significant reduction from 2025’s 315.07 GW. This was the first downward revision of the annual installation forecast.

Global outlook:

BloombergNEF forecasts 2026 global PV additions at **612 GW**, down 8% YoY, with growth resuming from 2027 and reaching **864 GW by 2030**

India is expected to be the only major market with higher installations in 2026 than 2025

China's policy adjustments will significantly influence the global total

1.4 Long-Term Targets

The 15th Five-Year Plan (2026–2030) targets an additional **969 GW** of wind and solar capacity, averaging nearly **200 GW annually**. By 2035, the wind and solar installation target remains **3,600 GW**.

The CPIA roadmap projects China's annual PV installations to reach **238–287 GW** during the 15th Five-Year Plan period, with growth resuming after 2027.

Part 2: Manufacturing Output

2.1 Production Volumes (H1 2026)

All four segments of the PV manufacturing chain contracted in H1 2026:

Segment	H1 2026 Output	YoY Change
Polysilicon	538,000 tons	-9.8%
Silicon Wafers	293 GW	-7.3%
Solar Cells	260.7 GW	-21.9%
PV Modules	201.3 GW	-35.1%

Source: CPIA, July 23, 2026

The industry has been mired in losses since 2024 due to severe overcapacity and a prolonged decline in module prices. The battery and module segments saw particularly sharp declines, with drops exceeding 20% and 30% respectively.

2.2 Price Trends

PV product prices showed volatile downward movement in H1 2026:

Product	Price Change (vs January 2026)
Polysilicon	-42.3%
Silicon Wafers	-28.7%
Solar Cells	-27.7%
PV Modules	+3.0%

Source: CPIA

Prices peaked in late January (wafers/cells) and March (modules) due to export tax rebate timing, then declined after the policy deadline.

2.3 Industry Rationalization

The MIIT has identified PV as a key sector for **mandatory national standards** and “involution-style” competition regulation. The government will

use capacity warnings, replacement mechanisms, and enterprise consultations to regulate competition.

The State Administration for Market Regulation has also issued price compliance guidance for the PV industry, calling on companies to strengthen cost management and resist malicious low-price competition.

The shift from 13% to 9% export tax rebate in December 2024, followed by complete elimination effective April 1, 2026, has accelerated industry consolidation and forced manufacturers to compete on fundamentals rather than subsidies.

Part 3: Export Data

3.1 Total Export Value

H1 2026 PV product exports (wafers, cells, modules): \$17.18 billion, up **24.3% year-over-year**. This marks the first positive growth since the H2 2023 downturn.

Quarterly trend:

Q1 2026: Strong export performance

Q2 2026: Slower growth due to March pre-policy surge pulling demand forward

Monthly component exports:

March 2026: 32.0 GW — the strongest March in three years, driven by pre-tax-rebate rush

April 2026: In line with 2024/2025 levels

May 2026: **\$1.789 billion**, down 13% YoY and 27% MoM; volume 14.09 GW, down from April

June 2026: ****\$2.15 billion****, up from \$1.92 billion in June 2025

3.2 Export Volume

H1 2026 component exports: 117.7 GW, down **0.5%** from 118.3 GW in H1 2025.

Monthly volume:

Month	Export Volume (GW)	Notes
March 2026	32.0	Pre-tax-rebate surge
May 2026	14.09	Post-policy adjustment
June 2026	18.1	Rebound from May, but below 2024/2025 levels

On a per-unit basis, exports fell 16.5% to 743.2 million units in June, marking the second consecutive monthly decline since the VAT export rebate withdrawal.

3.3 Export Mix

Product	H1 2026 Export Volume Change
Silicon Wafers	-0.6%
Solar Cells	+36.8%
PV Modules	-2.5%

Source: General Administration of Customs

Cell exports are growing significantly, driven by overseas capacity expansion, with cells now accounting for nearly 20% of total export value. Wafers and cells are showing a further growth trend, with cell export growth being particularly pronounced.

3.4 Top Export Destinations (H1 2026)

Rank	Country/Region	Volume (GW)
1	Netherlands	16.4
2	Pakistan	6.42
3	Philippines	5.46
4	Brazil	—
5	Spain	—
6	Australia	—
7	France	—